

Measles and Rehabilitation

Why rehabilitation is essential to the clinical management of severe measles and its complications.

Did you know?

Rehabilitation professionals play a critical role in the clinical management of measles — particularly for patients who develop severe complications requiring hospital or intensive care.

WHAT IS REHABILITATION IN MEASLES?

Measles is a highly contagious airborne disease caused by a virus that can lead to severe complications and death. Rehabilitation interventions can help prevent acute deterioration, support recovery, and reduce long-term functional impairments following measles infection.

Common complications of measles requiring rehabilitation input include:

- Pneumonia
- Dysphagia due to severe mouth sores
- Critical illness
- Post Intensive Care Syndrome (PICS)
- Encephalitis (affecting 1–3 of every 1,000 children)

In areas where vaccination rates are low or declining, local and national outbreaks are increasingly likely and can quickly overwhelm local health services. Those planning for potential surges in cases must be aware of the essential role rehabilitation professionals play in the clinical management of the critically unwell, particularly paediatric patients, and should include rehabilitation professionals in preparedness, readiness, and response planning.

CURRENT SITUATION

95k

measles deaths globally in 2024, mostly unvaccinated or under-vaccinated children under 5 (WHO)

11M

cases globally in 2024 — 800,000 more than pre-pandemic levels in 2019

59

countries reporting large or disruptive measles outbreaks in 2024 — nearly triple the number in 2021



ROLE OF REHABILITATION

Rehabilitation plays an essential role in the clinical management of measles, particularly for patients who develop severe complications requiring hospital or intensive care.

- **Preventing acute deterioration:** early rehabilitation interventions reduce the risk of complications associated with critical illness, immobility and prolonged hospital stays.
- **Supporting recovery:** rehabilitation professionals help manage the physical, respiratory and neurological consequences of measles complications, including post-intensive care rehabilitation for those with PICS.
- **Reducing long-term impairments:** targeted rehabilitation reduces the functional impact of complications such as encephalitis, supporting cognitive and physical recovery.
- **Paediatric care:** rehabilitation professionals play a particular role in the management of critically unwell children, where specialist input can significantly affect outcomes.

ACTIONS NEEDED

- Include rehabilitation professionals in preparedness, readiness and response planning for measles outbreaks, particularly in settings where vaccination rates are low or declining.
- Ensure rehabilitation professionals working in critical care settings are trained and prepared to manage the complications of measles, including in paediatric populations.
- Prioritise vaccination programmes as the primary means of preventing measles outbreaks and reducing the burden on health systems, including rehabilitation services.
- Collect data on the rehabilitation needs of measles survivors to strengthen the evidence base and improve future preparedness and response.

*Vaccination prevents measles — rehabilitation helps manage its consequences.
As outbreaks resurge, rehabilitation professionals must be part of preparedness, response, and recovery to protect the most vulnerable.*

About the World Rehabilitation Alliance

The World Rehabilitation Alliance is a WHO-hosted global network of more than 100 member organisations advancing rehabilitation in health systems and the recognition of functioning as a dimension of population health. Anchored in the Rehabilitation 2030 Initiative and WHA Resolution 76.6 (2023), the Alliance convenes partners across health, policy, and the wider development community.